Horrible Harry in Room 2B

By Suzy Kline

INTRODUCTION

Remember, when you were in 2nd grade? Sitting in those uncomfortable desks that housed all your worldly-school possessions. The teacher poses a question to the class…and there was always that one kid… The kid you thought was about to dislocate his shoulder. The kid who was jumping out of his seat crying "Oh, Oh, Oh." The kid who begged for the teacher to "Pick Me! Pick Me! I KNOW the answer." Well that kid was nothing compared to Harry in Suzy Kline's Horrible Harry in Room 2B.

Harry sits next to me in Room 2B. He looks like any other second grader except for one thing. Harry loves to do horrible things.

On the first day of school, Harry was out on the playground holding a shoebox. I asked him, "What's in there?"

"Something. Want to see a girl scream?"

Before I could say anything, Harry took off after Song Lee. When he trapped her by the tree,

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he opened up his box and dangled a garter snake in her face. Song Lee screamed! That's when I first saw Harry do something horrible this year.

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When it rains, we have recess indoors. Sometimes we play a game called "Seven Up." When it's Harry's turn to be up, everyone wonders, *Will Harry tap me on the head?* Harry presses his knuckles down hard on your skull. He calls them knuckle noogies. Nobody should give anybody a knuckle noogie. But Harry does.

Harry loves to do horrible things. The second week of school, Sidney called Harry a name. It was during science when we were reading about birds. "Harry's a canary!" Sidney whispered. And a lot of kids laughed.

"What's so funny?" the teacher asked.

"Nothing, Miss Mackle," Sidney replied.

Harry didn't think it was nothing. Harry planned to get revenge after school. And he did. At 3:05, Harry jumped Sidney, pinned him to the

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ground, and said, "Say *I Love Girls* twice."

"Never!" Sidney said, trying to get away.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

And that's when Harry started to tickle Sidney under the armpits until Sidney couldn't stand it any longer. *"I LOVE GIRLS! I LOVE GIRLS!"* Sidney shouted.

Song Lee, Ida, and Mary heard Sidney. So did a lot of the boys. Harry got his revenge all right. And it was horrible.

Sidney ran down the street screaming, "I'll get you back someday!"

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When Miss Mackle wants the floor cleaned, she asks Harry to sweep. No one sweeps the floor like Harry. He picks up every piece of paper, every pencil stub, and every bit of clay. Once Harry even crawled under my desk to get a broken crayon! Nobody knows that Harry *keeps* some of that stuff. But I do. I sit right next to him and watch. Harry is

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making stub people!

Harry says his stub people are the scariest creatures in the world. He keeps them in a cigar box in his desk. Someday, when he has made twenty-four, Harry says, his stub people will invade our room.

"It won't be long," he whispered. "Soon, the stub people will bring *doom* to Room 2B."

When it was Song Lee's birthday, her mother brought in two trays of treats for the class. After we sang "Happy Birthday," Song Lee passed out the treats. Miss Mackle noticed there were three fortune cookies and one cupcake left. Miss Mackle put them on a plate with a card that said WE LOVE MRS. MICHAELSEN. Then she said, "Who would like to take these treats to our librarian?"

Everyone raised their hand except Song Lee. She's too shy. We kept raising our hands. Sidney made noises like, "Oooooo... Me! Me! Me!"

Miss Mackle picked Harry and me. She knows we're not afraid to go upstairs where the big kids

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are.

When we were walking up the stairs to the library, Harry asked me if I wanted to split the cupcake.

"That's for the librarian," I said.

"Mrs. Michaelsen just likes yogurt and carrots," Harry replied. "We'll be doing her a favor."

And so we both promised, "Cross my heart, hope to die, stick a needle in my eye," that we would *never* tell on each another. Then we ate the librarian's cupcake. Sometimes Harry gets me to do horrible things.

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The day before Columbus Day, Harry came to school with a tattoo on his arm. It was a skull and crossbones. Harry said the sea pirate Long John Silver made his tattoo.

I know Harry did it with a Magic Marker. I think he just wanted to show off in front of Song Lee.

When Harry went to his seat, he took out his

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writing folder. He wrote two pages about his adventures at sea. Miss Mackle asked him to read his story to the class. Harry said he met a mermaid, ate a sea turtle, and dug up a treasure. Miss Mackle put Harry's story up on the bulletin board. She said Harry has lots of ideas.

Harry has never eaten a sea turtle. Harry has never seen a mermaid. Harry has never been to sea! And I know Harry can't even spell "sea." He's horrible at spelling too.

Harry is not like any other second grader in our room. I know *all* about him. Harry's my best friend.

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The day before Halloween, Harry planned his invasion.

"It's time to bring *doom* to our room," he said. I knew what he was talking about. It was time for the invasion of his stub people.

"Do you need help?" I asked.

"You can be my assistant."

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We put the first pair of stub people in Song Lee's desk while she was up at the pencil sharpener. When she returned, she reached in her desk for a piece of paper.

Harry plugged his ears. "I love it when girls scream," he said. "Look out for *doom!*" I plugged my ears. Song Lee didn't scream. She didn't even jump out of her seat. Harry and I watched Song Lee play with the stub people. She made them dance on the top of her desk!

Harry scowled. "This is an *invasion,*" he complained. "My stub people aren't dancers. They are invaders! They bring *doom* to our room!" I nodded.

Harry leaned over and whispered. "*Next* time, we have to catch the enemy by *real* surprise."

When Harry and I got permission to go to the bathroom, we stopped in the hallway. We slipped some stub people in Sidney's sweater sleeves. *Perfect,* we thought. When it came time to line up for lunch, Harry and I waited. Slowly, Sidney put on

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his sweater. And we watched. Sidney would jump up and scream any minute now!

But when Sidney put his arm in the sleeve, the stub people fell through and landed on the floor. Sidney never saw them. Neither did Ida or Mary. They stepped on them!

Harry kneeled down and scraped the stub people off the floor. Gently, he wrapped them in his handkerchief. We buried them in the garbage during lunch recess. And we gave them a farewell salute.

"This means war!" Harry exclaimed. "We've lost too many men. We have to invade the mainland now."

"What's the mainland?" I asked. "You'll see," Harry said.

Just before the bell rang, Harry put two pairs of stub people on the teacher's desk.

"The *teacher's desk?"* I said.

"The teacher's desk," Harry repeated. "Prepare for *doom* in our room!" Then he sat up straight and folded his hands on his desk.

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When the bell rang, Miss Mackle walked in. "I can see Harry is ready for class," she said.

"Plug your ears," Harry whispered as Miss MackIe walked to her desk. "She's going to scream and jump right out the window."

"What's this?" Miss Mackle said when she saw the stub people. Harry took his fingers out of his ears. I did too. "How cute!" Miss Mackle exclaimed as she held one up.

"Cute?" Harry said.

"Cute?" I said. Harry and I gave each other a look. How could that be? The stub people are the scariest creatures on earth. Harry put his head down on his desk, and buried his face in his arms. Sometimes it's real hard for Harry to be horrible.

"Cheer up," I said "tomorrow's Halloween. That's your favorite holiday. You'll be real scary then."

Harry looked up. "Halloween ... " He grinned. Nobody knew what Harry was going to be for Halloween, but everybody knew it would be something

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horrible.

Just before the 3 o'clock bell rang, we talked about it.

"Are you going to be Frankenstein?" Ida asked Harry.

Harry flashed his white teeth. "Scarier than that."

"Are you going to be a skeleton?" Mary said.

Harry shook his head. "Much, much scarier than that."

"Are you going to be a vampire?" Song Lee asked.

Harry shook his head again, "You'll never guess."

Sidney said, "Oh yes, I will. I bet you're going to be a canary!" And he laughed and laughed.

"Just beware, Sidney. Halloween is tomorrow." Then Harry leaned forward and shouted, "BOO!" Sidney jumped a foot in the air.

The next morning in school, everyone watched the door and waited for Harry. When a huge witch

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came in, everyone shivered. "It's *Harry!*" they shouted. And then the witch took off her green mask.

Good morning, boys and girls," a voice said. It was Miss Mackle!

After we said the pledge, I looked over at Harry's seat. It was empty. Where was Harry? And then, at 9:05, a very big Count Dracula showed up at the door. Everyone really shivered! "It's *Harry!*" they shouted.

And then a voice said, "Happy Halloween, boys and girls." It was the principal, Mr. Cardini.

Then, at 9:10, something slithered into the room. It was long and striped. It had a thin red tongue.

"Aaaauuugh!" screamed Sidney. Miss Mackle walked over to look.

"And who are you?" she asked. The snake slithered across the classroom floor, and everyone screamed! The snake went "Sssssss ... " Miss Mackle started to tap her foot. "If it's who I think it is, you're ten minutes late for school."

Everyone leaned forward to see. A head

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popped out of the snake skin, and flashed his white teeth.

"Harry!" everyone shouted.

"You're late," Miss Mackle said. "Snakes don't move that quickly,"

Harry replied. "It took me a long time to slither across the playground."

"Well, you'll have to make up the extra time after school," Miss Mackle said. "Ten minutes."

Harry made a face. Sidney beamed. "My watch says nine-twelve." Harry glared at Sidney.

[See . . .] sometimes Harry is so horrible he has to stay after school.

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